



Vector

AI plans.
You accomplish.

GUIDE FOR SOLOPRENEURS

THE 5-STEP METHOD

The anti-surprise system

For solopreneurs juggling multiple projects who want to stop ending every month in crisis mode.

BY **VECTOR** · AI PLANS. YOU ACCOMPLISH.

READ TIME · ~15 MIN

5 steps to **anticipate**, not react.

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BEFORE YOU START

This guide is designed to be applied this week, not studied. Keep a pen nearby — there are three short exercises along the way.

This isn't a **discipline** problem.

If you juggle multiple projects and end too many months in crisis mode, the most common diagnosis — "I lack discipline" — is also the most wrong.

Most overwhelmed solopreneurs don't work too little. They work **enormously**. The real problem: they have no way to see their actual workload before it becomes a crisis.

Without a system, your brain juggles three tasks at once: doing the work, remembering what's left to do, and anticipating what's coming. The last two consume enormous mental energy — and that's where the system fails, not in execution.

THE CORE IDEA

Getting blindsided by a deadline is almost always the symptom of a gap in your system, not a gap in your calendar. The goal of this guide: close those gaps so the surprises become rare.

The five steps that follow form a complete system. You can implement them over a weekend. But first, let's look at what it really costs to keep going without one.

What overwhelm really costs you.

The cost of missed deadlines isn't measured in overtime hours. It's measured in three zones harder to see — and harder to repair.

1

Sunday anxiety

You feel like you've forgotten something but you don't know what. Sunday evening becomes a gray zone instead of a moment of recovery.

2

Quality that slips

You deliver at the last minute, so you deliver below your standard. The iterations that make the difference get cut for lack of time.

3

Trust that erodes

Each "small delay" chips away at the client relationship, even when you eventually deliver. Long term, the best clients leave quietly.

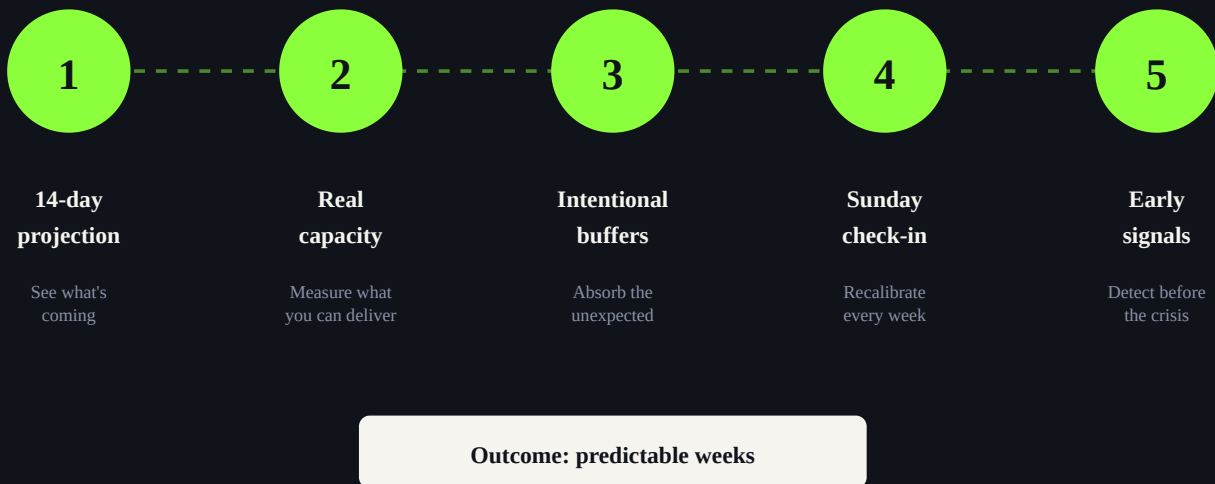
And the tipping cost.

Past a certain threshold, the mental cost of managing overwhelm becomes greater than the cost of doing the work itself. That's the moment when many solopreneurs start unconsciously avoiding new projects — out of fear, not strategy.

The good news: the system that follows treats all three symptoms at once, because they share the same cause. Lack of visibility.

Five steps. Twenty minutes a week.

Here's the complete structure. Each step gets detailed in the following pages, but you can already see the whole picture.



Steps 1, 2, and 3 are **installations** you do once. Steps 4 and 5 are **rituals** you maintain. This combination — install then maintain — is what makes the system robust.

The 14-day projection.

The problem with "today / tomorrow" lists is they show you what you're going to do — not what's coming.

As long as your planning horizon stays at the next 48 hours, you're structurally unable to see conflicts before they explode. Missed deadlines never come out of nowhere. They were visible for 10 days, but your system wasn't showing them to you.

How to do it

List every task you're committed to over the next 14 days. Not in blocks ("client X project"). Task by task, with a precise due date and an estimated duration in hours.

The inventory must include external commitments (client deliverables, meetings, fixed appointments) **and** internal commitments (admin, invoicing, prospecting, follow-ups).

EXERCISE

Open a blank page. In 10 minutes, write down every pending task for the next 14 days with its due date. If you forget some during the exercise, that's exactly the problem this step solves.

Why 14 days, not 7 or 30

Seven days is too short: you don't see the conflicts forming past Friday. Thirty days is too long: you add noise and uncertainty that make the system less useful, not more.

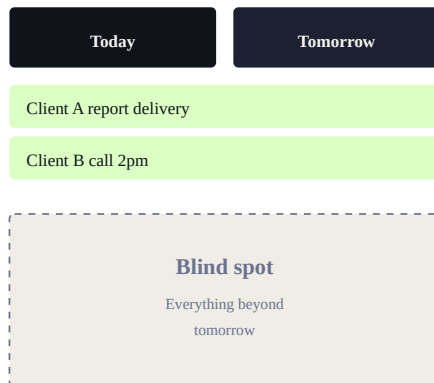
Fourteen days is the window where your commitments are firm enough to plan and close enough for the estimates to hold.

What you see changes everything.

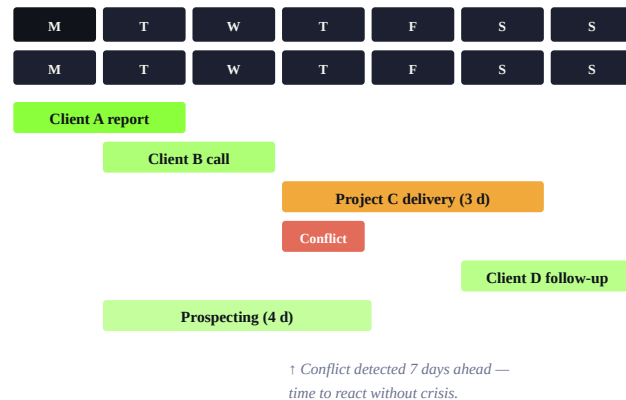
On the left, the typical view of a solopreneur without a system: today, sometimes tomorrow. On the right, the 14-day projection. The difference isn't in the work to do — that's identical. The difference is in **what you can anticipate**.

2-DAY VIEW VS 14-DAY VIEW

SHORT VIEW (2 DAYS)



PROJECTION VIEW (14 DAYS)



THE KEY INSIGHT

It's not the amount of work that changes. It's your ability to see a conflict 7 days before it arrives — and resolve it calmly, rather than suffer through it.

The **capacity** inventory.

The 14-day projection shows you what needs doing. But it's useless if you ignore how many hours you **actually** have to do it.

Most solopreneurs overestimate their productive capacity by 40 to 60%. They count gross work hours. But between emails, unscheduled calls, project-to-project transitions, necessary cognitive breaks, and invisible admin — there's rarely more than 60% of available time left for deliverable work.

The 60% rule

Start with your theoretical hours per week. Subtract 40%. That's your real capacity for deliverable work.

THE BASE CALCULATION

40 theoretical hours per week (5 days × 8 h)

– 16 h spent on admin, email, transitions, and the unexpected

= 24 h actually available for deliverables.

This number — 24 h — is what you should use to plan your 14-day projection. Not 40. Otherwise, you're building your plan on sand.

If that sounds low, it is. And that's exactly why most solopreneurs end up in crisis mode: they planned 40 h of work into 24 h of real capacity.

Where your time really goes.

A theoretical 40-hour week, broken down. The green portion is what's left for deliverable work — the only part that actually moves your projects forward.

TYPICAL WEEK BREAKDOWN

40 theoretical hours



LEGEND: 16 NON-DELIVERABLE HOURS

- Admin:** bookkeeping, invoicing, task tracking, paperwork
- Email:** replies, reading, triage, communication follow-up
- Unexpected:** urgent requests, technical issues, client emergencies
- Transitions:** cognitive cost of switching from one project to another

EXERCISE

For one week, honestly track how many hours you spend on deliverable work (not just work). Don't cheat. Most solopreneurs discover they're at 50%, not 60%.

Once you have your real number, that becomes your planning constraint. Never 40 again.

Intentional buffers.

A buffer is time reserved for **nothing**. It sounds counterintuitive. Yet it's the piece that keeps the whole system intact when a project slips — and a project always slips.

Without buffers, your plan is a chain. Break a link and you break the whole chain after it. A meeting that runs 30 minutes over pushes your entire day. A client who replies late delays three other deliverables.

With buffers, your plan becomes a net. A slip gets caught in the nearest buffer, without contaminating the rest.

Three types of buffers

TYPE 1

End-of-week buffer

1 to 2 hours on Friday afternoon, never planned. Used to absorb anything that slipped during the week. If nothing slipped, you leave early or get ahead.

TYPE 2

Pre-delivery buffer

10 to 15% of the estimated time of a deliverable, added before the planned date. A project estimated at 10 hours gets planned over 11.5 hours. The margin absorbs last-minute adjustments and late client feedback.

TYPE 3

Recovery buffer

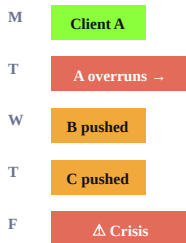
Half a day per month, completely empty. Not for catching up. For decompressing, cleaning up your system, or simply breathing. This is the buffer you'll be most tempted to cut — and the one to protect most fiercely.

What happens when a project slips.

Same scenario: a Client A deliverable overruns by 4 hours. On the left, without a buffer. On the right, with one. The difference isn't in the work to catch up — it's in **what happens next**.

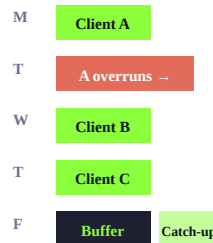
EFFECT OF A 4-HOUR OVERRUN

WITHOUT BUFFER



*Domino effect over 4 days.
Weekend sacrificed.
Anxiety + overtime.*

WITH BUFFER



*Catch-up absorbed Friday.
No other task affected.
Weekend intact.*

REMEMBER

A buffer isn't wasted time. It's insurance. You pay a small guaranteed cost (~10% of your capacity) to avoid a big random one (a week in crisis mode every month).

The Sunday check-in.

Twenty minutes. Every Sunday evening. Three questions. This is the step that turns a frozen plan into a living system.

Without a weekly ritual, your 14-day projection goes stale within days. With one, it stays calibrated continuously — and that continuous calibration is what separates a system you endure from a system you pilot.

The three questions

01 What slipped this week?

And where it landed. Not to blame yourself — to understand. A task that slips three times in a row isn't a late task, it's a task that's poorly defined or poorly estimated.

02 What's coming in the next 14 days that I hadn't anticipated?

New project, email received, deadline approaching. Add it to the 14-day projection and check whether it creates a conflict with your capacity.

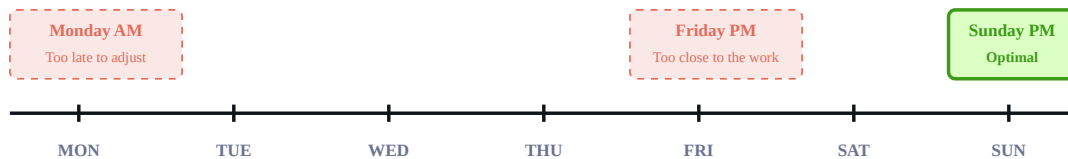
03 Has my real capacity changed?

Vacation coming up, illness, time off, persistent overload. Your capacity isn't constant — your plan must reflect your actual week, not a fictional one.

Why Sunday evening.

The timing of the ritual isn't neutral. Sunday evening offers a unique combination: enough distance from the ending week to see it clearly, and enough proximity to Monday for the adjustment to matter.

THE OPTIMAL WINDOW



Emotional distance + proximity to action = maximum clarity

Variation

If Sunday evening is sacred to you (family, rest, principle), shift to Monday morning **before** you start working. Not during the day. Not after a meeting. The rule: the check-in must precede the week's action, not follow it.

AVOID

Doing the check-in Friday end of day. You're tired, you want to disconnect, you'll skim. Result: you start the following week with an uncalibrated system.

Early drift **signals.**

A missed deadline starts forming ten days in advance. The problem is that we ignore it — because we don't know what to look at.

Here are the four indicators that warn you a project is slipping, well before the deadline arrives. When a signal goes off, you have 48 hours to react before it becomes a crisis.

1 CALENDAR SIGNAL

Three days without measurable progress

Not "three days without working on it". Three days without a concrete deliverable produced. If you're working on it but nothing's moving, it's a task-breakdown problem.

2 ESTIMATION SIGNAL

Actual time > 30% over estimate

The first tasks of a project are the most predictable. If they're already 30% over, the rest will overrun more. Re-project the whole sequence.

3 DEPENDENCY SIGNAL

External response pending > 48 h

Client, vendor, collaborator. Past 48 h without a reply, you're not waiting anymore — you're blocked. Action: proactive follow-up or workaround.

4 EMOTIONAL SIGNAL

You start avoiding the project

The subtlest, the most reliable. When you systematically choose to work on something else, your brain has already detected a problem. Listen to it.

ASK YOURSELF

Right now, which project has at least one signal already on — and you haven't addressed it yet? The answer comes in less than 5 seconds. That's exactly the project to recalibrate this week.

What to do in the next 48 hours.

Detecting a signal without acting on it is worse than not detecting anything — because it creates a false sense of control. Here's the action protocol based on how many signals are on for the same project.

1 SIGNAL

Re-project the internal deadline. Not the external one (client) — the deadline you set for yourself. Add 20% time. Check that it still fits within your weekly capacity.

2 SIGNALS

Action required: remove or postpone another task to free up capacity. You can't add time that doesn't exist. Something must come out of the plan.

3 SIGNALS OR MORE

Immediate client conversation. Not in a week — now. The goal: renegotiate the deadline or the scope before the project officially falls behind. This is the moment when honesty costs the least.

The golden rule

A crisis detected 10 days in advance costs 1 conversation. The same crisis detected 2 days in advance costs 1 difficult conversation + overtime + a strained client relationship. The same crisis detected at the deadline costs you the client.

Early signals aren't a prediction system. They're a **cost-reduction** system. Pay earlier, pay less.

No **complicated tool** required.

The system was designed to run on what you already have. The method always comes before the tool.

The bare minimum

Three things are enough to start this week:

1 A spreadsheet or a paper sheet

For your 14-day projection. Columns: task, project, estimated duration, due date, status. Excel, Google Sheets, Numbers, or a notebook — all of them work.

2 A calendar

The one you already use. To block your buffers (step 3) and mark your Sunday ritual (step 4) as a recurring appointment.

3 20 minutes on Sunday

Blocked in your calendar. Recurring. Non-negotiable. The one "tool" we always forget to install.

The trap to avoid

Many solopreneurs spend a whole weekend picking and configuring the perfect tool — and never use the method. That's avoidance dressed up as productivity.

Start with a simple sheet. If after two weeks you feel the method holds, then look at whether a dedicated tool helps. Not before.

When the system starts to weigh.

The manual system works very well for 1 or 2 projects. Starting at 3, something changes — not in the method, but in its maintenance cost.

The more projects you add, the more time you spend **maintaining the system** grows non-linearly. Why? Because each new project adds not only its own maintenance cost, but also the cost of checking its compatibility with every existing project — conflicts of resources, deadlines, capacity. At 5 projects, you maintain 5 plans but you also check **10 potential interaction pairs**. That combinatorial effect is what widens the gap.

WEEKLY MAINTENANCE TIME BY NUMBER OF PROJECTS

ACTIVE PROJECTS	MAINTENANCE / WEEK	MENTAL LOAD
1 project	~20 min	Negligible
2 projects	~45 min	Light
3 projects	~1 h 15	Moderate
4 projects	~1 h 50	Significant
5 projects or more	~2 h 30	Heavy

Taken alone, 2 h 30 per week may seem reasonable. But it's over **10% of your 24 deliverable hours** — spent organizing the work rather than doing it. And the mental load of holding 5 projects in your head doesn't show up on a clock. Not a discipline failure — a structural limit of solo multi-project work.

We built Vector for **exactly this moment.**

When the system starts to weigh more than it delivers, the real question isn't "how do I get more disciplined?", but "how do I automate what I was doing by hand?".

That's exactly what Vector does. The method stays yours. The maintenance becomes the AI's.

WHAT ARTHUR, YOUR AI CHIEF PLANNING OFFICER, DOES

→ 14-Day Projection

Built and kept up to date automatically each time you add a task.

→ Continuous Replanning

Every time a task moves, the whole plan recalculates.

→ Signal Detection

Continuous. You get an alert the moment a project enters a risk zone.

→ Calculated Capacity

Based on your real history, not theoretical estimates.

→ Semi-Automatic Check-In

Arthur prepares your Sunday summary; you validate in 5 minutes.

→ You Stay in Control

AI proposes, you validate. Never the other way around.

You keep the method you just learned. You only get rid of the maintenance cost that grows with every new project.

AI plans. You accomplish.

TRY VECTOR

Start **free**. Today.

No credit card. No demo to schedule. You create an account and Arthur starts working with you in under 10 minutes.

Foundation

\$0 / lifetime

2 active projects · Weekly and morning briefing · Automated task scheduling to your calendar · Core AI planning features · To test the method with no commitment.

RECOMMENDED

Acceleration

\$29 / month

Unlimited projects · Reports · All AI planning features · For solopreneurs juggling 3 projects or more.

Delegation

\$79 / month

Acceleration + an AI Chief Operating Officer that executes · Up to 2 dedicated AI employees automating your repetitive tasks · To automate beyond planning.

Propulsion

\$119 / month

Delegation + unlimited AI employees · White-label · For solopreneurs that nothing can stop.

LAUNCH OFFER

Sign up during the beta and get **30 days of Acceleration free** in exchange for feedback within your first 14 days. You also get **priority access to Delegation and Propulsion** before their public release, with a free trial period for each. Foundation access stays for life, no card required.

VECTOR.

NEXT STEP

Stop planning. Start accomplishing.

You have the method. You can apply it manually starting this week. Or let Arthur handle all of it — while you focus on the only work that really matters: yours.

Try Vector free →

vectorplanning.ai